Reimagining the work day

Joel Hellermark thinks AI will make everyone a polymath at work

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Somewhere inside Workday, an engineer is apparently instructing AI agents while out windsurfing in the middle of the week. And his boss somehow considers that work, believe it or not, according to Joel Hellermark, Chief AI Officer at Workday.

But that's exactly the kind of unimaginable workday scenarios AI will enable more into the future. "You wake up and you check in on your fleet of AI agents and it feels like you're conducting this orchestra. You're overseeing any escalations that they've done. You're checking in on their progress," Joel Hellermark tells me in an exclusive interview with Digit.



Joel Hellermark
Chief AI Officer, Workday

Throughout my conversation with Hellermark one thing becomes clear. He isn't particularly interested in building a faster version of today's office, he actually wants to make most of it obsolete.

"I think the industrialization of knowledge work is quite depressing. We go into these huge buildings and we sit there and click through SaaS systems all day. Thanks to AI, I think there's going to be a lot more time to do the things that we're uniquely capable of doing in the future."

It's an incredible admission from Workday's Chief AI Officer, given that his Fortune 500 employer built its entire business on precisely those SaaS systems that Hellermark wants to banish to history books.

An AI-enabled renaissance, not another factory

In my conversation, I find Hellermark's most locked-in belief isn't about software per se, but the people that software is ultimately supposed to serve. Across offices and industries, Hellermark sees knowledge locked in silos, people trapped in outdated workflows and information controlled by several layers. All potential bottlenecks to solve for.

Hellermark believes AI can dissolve some of those bottlenecks. He expects new graduates entering the workforce to instinctively get how to direct agents, even without decades of accumulated institutional expertise. And with that, Hellermark challenges one of the oldest assumptions about apprenticeship itself.

"I think knowledge transfer will be less important," he says. "The idea of sitting next to someone over a couple of years to maybe transfer that knowledge. I think you will have instant access to it going forward. And new grads will be the most AI-pilled people you have in your organizations."

In that case, what happens to corporate hierarchies inside big companies, I asked him? "I think it will be an inverted pyramid where the folks that historically have been at the bottom will be at the top. And the individual contributors will be the most valuable people in the organization. And a lot of the hierarchies of corporate management will dissolve."

For a company selling human-capital management software, that's a deliciously disruptive thought. Where Hellermark imagines teams assembling around tasks and missions rather than reporting hierarchies, and the future of work might require managing considerably fewer managers. Where humans become conductors of intelligent systems instead of being operators of applications.

"Yeah, I think this will be like the return of the polymath, a generation of Da Vinci's. And I think it will be much more like the Renaissance than the Industrial Revolution," imagines Joel Hellermark.

If AI takes away the routine assignments, the ones that give you a better understanding of your work, from juniors joining the workforce, where will the next generation learn and get their instincts from? On this note, Hellermark offers no detailed transition plan, assuming that valuable skills will change quickly. Workday's newly announced Work Intelligence, designed to separate jobs into tasks that AI can automate, augment or leave to humans, is one attempt to confront that problem. But that still doesn't answer the million-dollar question of how to build a career ladder when the lower rungs of upward mobility disappear with AI.

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